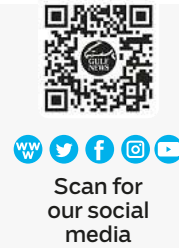


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UAE visitors to get VAT refund for e-commerce

DUBAI
BY MANOJ NAIR
Business Editor

The UAE has launched a world-first VAT refund system for tourists making e-commerce purchases during their stay, in collaboration with Planet, the VAT refund operator.

Tourists can apply for VAT refunds on online purchases through registered e-commerce platforms by providing travel documents and personal details to verify eligibility before purchases are shipped.

The refund is processed when the tourist leaves the UAE.

The UAE already offers VAT refunds for physical store purchases, and this new system extends the same benefit to online shopping. The VAT rate is 5 per cent. The system is fully digital, allowing tourists to easily reclaim VAT through scanned passports and digital invoices.

This move is expected to boost the local e-commerce market, particularly for high-priced products, benefiting both tourists and online retailers. The FTA aims to enhance the UAE's competitiveness and global digital innovation, reinforcing its leadership in tourism and e-commerce.

SEE ALSO P5



Evangeline Elsa/Gulf News

AMAZING DRONE SPECTACLE LIGHTS UP DUBAI SKY

Over 1,000 drones light up the night sky as part of the 30th anniversary of the Dubai Shopping Festival. The daily show, visible from Bluewaters and The Beach, JBR, runs until January 12, 2025, and takes place twice at 8pm and 10pm.

To watch the video of the show, scan the QR code



9 killed as bus overturns in Sharjah

Police say accident likely caused by brake failure

SHARJAH
BY AGHADDIR ALI
Senior Reporter

Nine passengers of Asian and Arab nationalities died when a bus carrying 83 workers overturned in Khor Fakkan, Sharjah, on Sunday evening. The accident

was likely due to brake failure, Sharjah Police said yesterday.

The police, in coordination with relevant authorities, quickly reached the scene, rescuing rest of the passengers, administering first aid to the injured, and transporting them to hospitals for medical care.

Brigadier Dr Ali Al Kay Al Hamoudi, Director of the Eastern Region Police Department, said the police operations room received a report

about a bus carrying workers that overturned at Wadi Wishi roundabout, at the entrance of Khor Fakkan. All relevant police, civil defence, and national ambulance teams quickly responded to the scene.

Brig Al Kay said preliminary investigations indicated that a brake failure was the main cause of the accident, which led to the driver losing control and the bus overturning at the right exit of the entrance to the city of Khor Fakkan.

Health cover must across UAE in 2025

INSURANCE MANDATORY FOR ISSUING OR RENEWING RESIDENCY PERMITS

DUBAI
BY SHARMILA DHAL
UAE Editor

All private sector employees and domestic workers in the UAE, irrespective of the emirate they are based in, will have to mandatorily get basic health insurance from the New Year.

Making the announcement yesterday, the Ministry of Human Resources and Emiratization (MoHRE) said the basic package, which has already been implemented in Dubai and Abu Dhabi, will extend coverage to private sector workers in Sharjah, Ajman, Umm Al Quwain, Ras Al Khaimah, and Fujairah from January 1, 2025.

Residency permits

The new policy will be prerequisite for issuing or renewing residency permits. But it will not apply to employees with work permits issued before January 1, 2024 that remain valid. They will only become mandatory when their residency permits are due for renewal.

The package will cost Dh320

yearly and will be valid for two years, with a provision to refund the second year's premium if the visa is cancelled.

Focus on health care

Khalil Al Khoori, Undersecretary of Labour Market and Emiratization Operations at MoHRE, said, "The Health Insurance Scheme reflects the UAE's commitment to extending the comprehensive protection system to all workers across the labour market, ensuring a decent life for all by providing access to high-quality health care services for private sector employees and domestic workers."

Major General Saeed Salem Balhas Al Shamsi, Acting Director-General of the Federal Authority for Identity, Citizenship, Customs, and Port Security, said the authority will be establishing an electronic link with various ministries, government entities and private sector institutions and will verify that all workers in the private and business sectors, as well as domestic workers, are covered by insurance before issuing residencies.

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